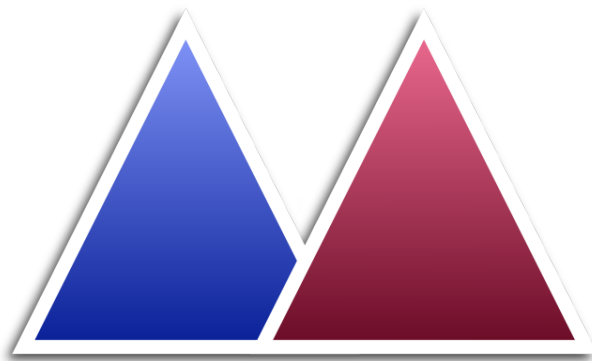




MAJU

EP-CCAs: A Different Ball Game

Centralised, non school-based CCAs hosted by external organisations

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PREFACE

MAJU is a ground-up initiative by people with a passion for policies. Specifically, we are Singaporean youths with aspirations for Singapore's future. From both media reports and personal experience, we believe there are many like-minded youths out there, who too have aspirations for Singapore and concrete policy ideas to realise them.

While there are many avenues for youths to voice their opinions, we felt that none of these platforms were suited for proposing concrete and detailed policy proposals. In our view, the best way of doing so was to formulate policy proposals independently and submit them directly to the Government for consideration.

However, this is a significant undertaking. Without encouragement and motivation from like-minded youths, a framework for organised and constructive research, or assistance and support from the Government themselves, youths are unlikely to formulate and propose their ideas.

This is where MAJU comes in. We gather like-minded youths so they can work in teams and not on their own. We provide a research framework so that proposals are sensible and balanced. And we partner with MCCY and NYC so that teams receive assistance and support from the Government. In doing so, we provide a platform for all Singaporean youths, passionate about policies, to organise, research and actualize their ideas.

At a recent dialogue at the Istana, President Halimah Yacob endorsed efforts in this spirit, saying that youths should "take opportunities to give feedback on and influence policies" (Ng, 2022). Most notably, she encouraged youths to organise and put up proposals to ministries and ministers because "the voices of youth are very much needed nowadays".

As youths, we lack experience, lack expertise, and lack a full view of the complexities and trade-offs of policy making. However, as our President said, we believe that our voices are needed - and that we have creative ideas and novel perspectives to bring to the table. It is our sincere desire that the ideas presented in this policy proposal, hopefully the first of many, will make a difference, big or small.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In secondary schools, CCAs are mandatory as they are critical to students' holistic development. However, CCA choices are also limited. This is due to factors such as manpower constraints, or lack of infrastructure for certain CCAs. Many students therefore do not get to join their desired CCAs. This results in a loss of sporting and artistic talent, while adversely impacting student enjoyment.

The Strategic Partnership-CCA (SP-CCA) pilot overcame some of these limitations. As such, we are proposing potential avenues of expansion. Additionally, we propose the formation of External Partnership-CCAs (EP-CCAs), where external organisations partner with MOE to offer novel and diverse CCAs. This will further meet students' varied interests.

SP-CCAs and EP-CCAs fulfill different policy goals. SP-CCAs, which increase access to existing CCA options, help surface more sporting and artistic talent. EP-CCAs, on the other hand, unlock access to new CCA options, for students to enjoy and learn.

We believe EP-CCA is a win-win policy: They will broaden exposure for students, while helping external organisations develop and expand. Moreover, EP-CCAs in areas of strategic interest such as mental health and sustainability can both achieve societal good and advance the Government's objectives.

This policy, like all policies, entails a set of trade offs. Through engaging key stakeholders such as MOE, students and external organisations, we have sought to produce a balanced proposal that advances all parties' interests while minimising additional costs and difficulties.

INTRODUCTION

1. CHOICE OF TOPIC

CCA participation is mandatory in all secondary schools, due to the critical role it plays in holistic development. However, CCAs are school-based. This means that apart from a few exceptions, students can only join CCAs that their school offers. If a student enjoys football but their school does not have a football CCA, they have to settle for another CCA offered by the school. The student cannot opt to join a different school's football team.

Based on Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) conducted with local students, there is a consensus that students are unlikely to choose secondary schools based on the CCAs offered. Other considerations, such as proximity and academic rigour, are prioritised above CCA variety. While the Direct School Admission (DSA) scheme is a notable exception, the scheme only benefits a minority of exceptionally-talented students in every cohort (Ng, 2021).

Additionally, the football-loving student is unlikely to join an external club to pursue their interest, on top of the mandatory school-based CCA. School-based CCAs are free, convenient, and a good place to make friends and develop a sense of shared belonging. This gives students little incentive to join external clubs, unless they are very interested. Students at Secondary 1 may lack the maturity to exercise initiative in such matters.

We are thus proposing a policy to expand the range of structured CCA options available to students.

1.1 Reasons for the Current Situation

We understand that schools are unable to provide a range of CCAs that meets every student's interests due to the following considerations.

1.1.a: Budget Considerations

Since CCAs incur coaching and equipment costs, the school cannot open new CCAs to cater to each student without incurring prohibitive costs. Rather, schools on average offer around 20 CCAs¹ that adequately meet the students' interests. With fewer CCAs, each CCA has more members, allowing the school to reap economies of scale on equipment and coaching costs. This strikes a balance between meeting students' needs and managing costs.

This was something that then-Education Minister Ong Ye Kung alluded to in 2020: "[The SP-CCA Pilot is] part of an ongoing development by the ministry to also tackle the lack of 'critical mass' to sustain certain CCAs and to work with limited resources" (Ong, 2020).

¹ This is based on a manual count of the number of CCAs offered by each secondary school as listed in the "Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022" booklet released by MOE. The actual average number of CCAs amongst secondary schools is 19.04.

1.1.b: Administrative Considerations

There are non-monetary considerations as well, such as teacher workload and deployment. On top of teaching, teachers undertake many responsibilities in CCAs, including mentoring students, updating CCA records, bidding for coaches, clearing RAMS, etc. Schools need to offer a quantity of CCAs commensurate with what their teachers can handle.

1.1.c: Availability of Facilities

Furthermore, schools are more likely to offer CCAs for which they have the facilities. A school lacking a football field could still rent an external venue - but that means additional rental costs, and additional work in arranging transport. It is much more feasible for schools to offer CCAs for which they have facilities.

1.1.d: Lack of Student Interest

Other than these three supply-side factors, there is a demand-side factor of student interest. If a school anticipates, based on past cohorts, that there will **not** be enough students interested to form a full football team, it may not be feasible to offer football as a CCA. Instead, the school may opt to offer other CCAs for which there may be sufficient interests.

1.2 Benefits from CCA Participation

MOE had renamed extra-curricular activities (ECAs) to CCAs in 1999 to send a clear message that “CCAs are an integral part of education” (Sim, n.d.), and not an addendum. This is because CCA participation is vastly beneficial.

1.2.a: Holistic Development of Students

CCAs allow students to discover their interests, build their character and develop socio-emotional competencies. Beyond the correlation with higher-than-expected academic achievement, CCA participation has been associated with improvements in self-esteem and resilience (Fredricks & Eccles, 2008).

1.2.b: CCAs Enable Social Mixing

CCAs also provide a platform for students from diverse backgrounds to learn together in an informal setting. Preliminary research suggests that the interpersonal skills acquired through CCAs might even drive social mobility, by boosting employment prospects (Donnelly, Lažetić, Sandoval-Hernandez, Kumar & Whewall, 2019).

1.2.c: Identifying Sporting Talent

CCAs are crucial to our High Performance Sports (HPS) ecosystem as they build a base of participation, from which talent can be identified and nurtured. One example of this is Micky Lin, who joined a netball CCA due to its similarities with captain's

ball, her sport of interest. She later matured into the national team captain and led Singapore to her first SEA Games ‘Gold’ for netball (Chim, 2019).

2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

2.1 Consequences of Limited CCA Choices

We believe that the limited availability of CCA choices in secondary schools leads to a loss of sporting and artistic talent and reduces student enjoyment. Furthermore, due to the current distribution of CCA choices amongst schools, students in different schools have unequal access to CCA choices.

2.1.a: Loss of Youth Talent

In the absence of CCAs, sporting and artistic talent will remain undiscovered. Only 84 out of the 134 co-ed or girls’ schools in Singapore offer netball as a CCA². In these 50 other schools, there may be young women, talents like Micky Lin, whose sporting potential are untapped.

Another prominent example is Ernie Sulastris, captain of the national women’s football team. She started playing as a child, but because her school did not offer football as a CCA, she had to resort to other means such as playing for the SAF Football Club (Ng, 2022). Only 68 out of the 134 co-ed or girls’ schools in Singapore offer football as a CCA³. Similarly, there may be untapped talent in the other 66 schools.

Generally, the larger the number of schools not offering a certain CCA, the larger the pool of untapped talent. Since there is a considerable lack of access for relatively common CCAs like netball and football, the pool of untapped talent for less common sports like canoeing, silat and wushu is even greater.

To develop talents to their maximum potential, early training and development is crucial. On average, Olympians start training for their sport in their mid-teens, and many start even earlier (Fielding, 2018). Scouting talent early increases the chance of success, due to a longer training duration. CCAs in secondary schools hence provide an ample runway to develop young sporting and artistic talent.

² This is again based on a manual count of the number of CCAs offered by each secondary school as listed in the "Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022" booklet released by MOE.

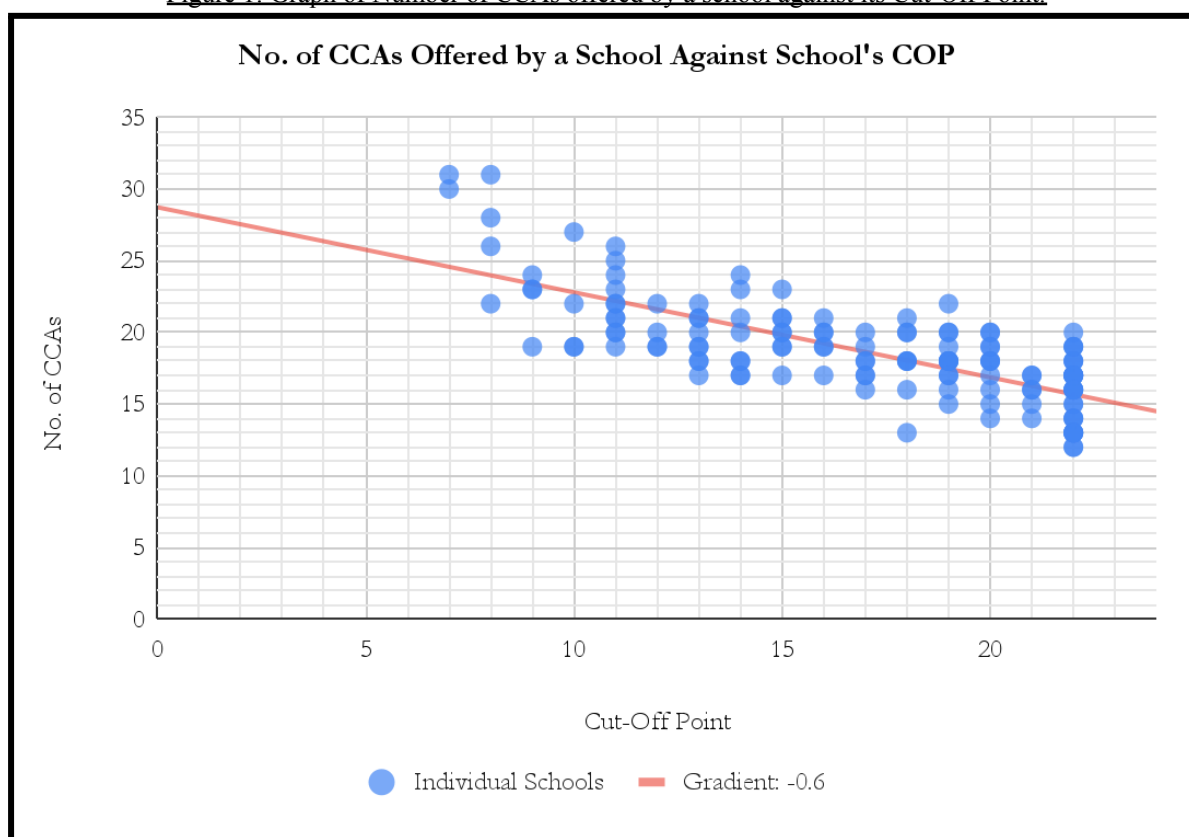
³ *Ibid.*

2.1.b: Reduced Equality of Opportunity

We analysed CCA offerings under individual schools in MOE's 'Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022' booklet.⁴ The number of CCAs ranges vastly, from 8 to 48. Access to CCAs is thus unequal.

Our analysis further found that the average number of CCAs offered in secondary schools decreased by 0.6 for every 1-point increase in the school's PSLE cut-off point (COP). Schools with higher COPs tend to admit students who had not performed well academically. This correlation thus suggests that less academically-inclined students also have less access to CCAs.

Figure 1: Graph of Number of CCAs offered by a school against its Cut-Off Point.



⁴ The number of CCAs and COP for each school was manually compiled from MOE's 'Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022' booklet. The graph was plotted using linear regression for 137 secondary schools out of 146. Nine outliers were excluded for the following reasons: Ping Yi Secondary School, Anglo-Chinese School (Independent), Raffles Girls' School, Raffles Institution, National Junior College and Temasek Junior College are excluded because they have an abnormally low or high number of CCAs. Spectra Secondary School and Crest Secondary School are excluded as they do not take part in the Secondary 1 posting exercise, while Yusof Ishak Secondary School is excluded as it is a new school without historical COP data.

2.1.c: Impacted Student Enjoyment

Our survey of secondary and post-secondary students⁵ found that students who did not join their desired CCAs still reported high levels of CCA enjoyment. On a scale from 1 to 10, the eighteen respondents who indicated that they did not join their desired CCA rated their CCA enjoyment an average score of 8. However, 10 of these 18 respondents also felt that they would have enjoyed their desired CCA more. Expanding the range of CCAs available to students might hence increase their enjoyment further.

It is a reasonable assumption that students who reported higher levels of CCA enjoyment would also be more likely to report a positive schooling experience. Our survey, however, did not ask respondents how much they felt CCAs had influenced their overall schooling experience, and this correlation was not explicitly established.

3. PROPOSED SOLUTION

Given the impacts of a limited range of CCAs on youth talent, equal access to opportunity and student enjoyment, we think MOE should consider expanding the range of CCAs offered in schools. While individual schools are constrained in offering more CCAs, MOE could instead offer more CCAs in a non-school based, centralised context.

It is not economical for individual schools to cater CCAs for specific interests, especially if demand is low and there are only a few students per school cohort who would take that CCA up. Moreover, schools may, on their own, lack proper facilities. However, by offering a non-school based CCA, pockets of interested students from various schools could be put together, making the CCA more economical to run. Each school would not need to have proper facilities as long as one of the participating schools does. Having non-school based, centralised CCAs would also augment the benefits of CCAs, by allowing students to mix with a more diverse group of peers.

We propose two pathways for doing so:

1. Increasing the number of Strategic Partnership CCAs, or SP-CCAs (Ong, 2020)
2. Partnering with external organisations to host non-school based, centralised CCAs known as External Partnership CCAs, or EP-CCAs

Details on both pathways are outlined below.

⁵ Post-secondary refers to students who had completed secondary school in the past two years or less. Although secondary school students are our target audience, we opened the survey to post-secondary students since we did not have enough respondents who were still in secondary school.

EXPANDING STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP-CCAs (SP-CCAs)

4. OVERVIEW

The SP-CCA pilot began in 2019, to “provide the opportunity for secondary school students to pursue a CCA that their schools do not offer” (MOE, 2022c). Then-Minister for Education Ong Ye Kung said the pilot would help “cater to the diverse CCA interests and talents of students (Ong, 2020)”.

Through the pilot, students in schools that did not offer athletics and ethnic dance could still join those CCAs at a non-school based, centralised location. These locations were the Singapore Sports Hub and the LASALLE College of the Arts respectively (Ong, 2020). They participated alongside students from other schools, which allowed students to mix with peers from diverse backgrounds (MOE, n.d.).

As of now, the Athletics SP-CCA has 52 students from 36 schools, while the Ethnic Dance CCA has 19 students from nine schools.⁶ Athletics was chosen as it is a sport that SportSG wants to focus on, while ethnic dance was chosen due to its cultural value. The choice of SP-CCA was guided by strategic interest.⁷

Other than the fact that CCAs were run at external, centralised locations rather than a school-based one, SP-CCAs functioned the same as school-based CCAs (MOE, n.d.). CCA sessions were run by qualified, MOE-registered coaches; students were encouraged to remain in the SP-CCA throughout secondary school; students could take part in competitions; and MOE POCs were provided to handle attendance taking etc.

5. FLAWS AND POSSIBLE MITIGATION

5.1 Concerns Raised from SP-CCA Pilot

From our preliminary discussion with MOE officers, students raised the following problems they had encountered during the SP-CCA pilot. However, we believe the concerns raised can be solved using mitigative measures.

5.1.a: Excessive Travelling Time

Athletics was conducted at the Kallang Practice Track while ethnic dance was conducted at LASALLE. Both are located downtown, particularly far away for schools in the West and North. Students who stay far away spend two or more hours travelling to-and-fro CCA training. Travelling costs and time were raised as concerns in FGDs as well.

⁶ This was shared with us by Mr Lee Lis King (Assistant Director, Student Development Coordination Office, MOE), during an engagement session between MAJU and MCCY & MOE.

⁷ *Ibid.*

However, this can be resolved by setting a limit on travelling time to ensure it is not excessive. For example, students from schools that are too far away from some SP-CCA locations may not attend that SP-CCA. Alternatively, multiple locations can be opened so that all students have viable options no matter their school.

5.1.b: Loss of Shared Identity

Some students were concerned that they missed out on potential friendships with schoolmates had they joined a school-based CCA instead. This, by extension, felt like a loss of shared identity with the school. This is plausible, as CCAs make up a significant aspect of student life

However, we believe curriculum time and other non-CCA programmes ultimately provide students an ample base for bonding with other schoolmates. Additionally, we believe this loss is outweighed by the gain in inter-school interactions. This has the added benefit of allowing students to befriend a more diverse group of students.

5.1.c: Scheduling Constraints

School-wide events such as Speech Day affects students from that school, but not the rest of the EP-CCA members from other schools. This can make scheduling a little complicated.

We expect scheduling constraints to occur once in a while, as school-specific events e.g. open house, Speech Day occur only once a year. These will not have a significant impact on SP-CCAs either way.

5.1.d: Malingering Concerns

Some parents indicated that they would not want their children to attend SP-CCAs since it involved travelling, in some cases a significant distance. Parents were then concerned that students would spend this time malingering instead of attending CCA.

This can be resolved through consistent communication between school teachers and teachers at the SP-CCA to ensure that students arrive punctually for SP-CCA.

6. AVENUES FOR EXPANSION

MCCY indicated plans to expand SP-CCAs in both Budget 2020 and 2021 (Singapore Parl Debates, 2020 & Singapore Parl Debates, 2021). Along these lines, we understand that MOE plans to start a team sports SP-CCA in the second half of this year. While the idea to expand SP-CCAs is already in the works, we hope to value-add by proposing additional SP-CCAs with strategic value and suggesting potential locations for said expansion.

6.1 Proposed CCAs (Sports)

6.1.a: Football

Football is one of the most, if not the most, popular sports in Singapore. The ‘Unleash the Roar’ project reflects Singapore’s ambition to qualify for the 2034 Football World Cup. To achieve this, talents must be identified at a young age and groomed through special development opportunities such as training stints in Europe, Japan or Korea.

Yet, 67 out of 144 secondary schools that take part in the Secondary 1 Posting Exercise (43%) do not offer football as a CCA at all. Of these 67 schools, some offer football as a male-exclusive CCA⁸. While existing programmes like exposure during PE lessons or the JSA programme help in this regard, a football SP-CCA would further expand the base of participation. The formation of inter-school football teams will also facilitate a natural transition to club-based football in the Singapore Premier League.

6.1.b: Badminton

National shuttler Loh Kean Yew’s success in the past two years has also led to an explosion of interest in badminton. This is an opportune time to identify and develop badminton talent. As with a football SP-CCA, a badminton SP-CCA will expand the base of participation. Currently, 44 out of 144 (30.6%) of secondary schools do not offer badminton as a CCA⁹.

To continue developing Singapore’s sporting scene, the government can strategically invest in sports such as football and badminton, which already garner widespread interest and support.

6.1.c: Miscellaneous

Another possible approach for future consideration would be to develop sports for which Singapore already has some degree of expertise and infrastructure. Water sports, such as sailing and swimming, are possible options. Regardless of the sport, the central tenet remains the same – to win medals on the international stage, talents must be identified from young, and expanding SP-CCAs to these areas will facilitate this scouting process.

⁸ Based on a manual count of the number of CCAs offered by each secondary school as listed in the "Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022" booklet released by MOE. While football is a male-exclusive CCA, some schools offer CCAs that are female-exclusive.

⁹ Based on a manual count of the number of CCAs offered by each secondary school as listed in the "Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022" booklet released by MOE. A CCA at 70% of schools, badminton is actually one of the most widely offered sports - perhaps due to the ubiquity of badminton courts in school halls, and the low equipment costs.

6.2 Proposed CCAs (Clubs)

6.2.a: Community Service

By expanding community service CCAs and offering them to more schools as a SP-CCA, students will have more structured opportunities to serve as compared to school VIA programmes, which are more ad-hoc. As community service is broad ranging, MOE could focus on strategic groups, such as the elderly.

6.2.b: Nature-based Clubs

With Singapore also striving towards carbon neutrality, nature-based SP-CCAs that cultivate students' environmental awareness have strategic value. Currently, only 23% of schools that take part in the Secondary 1 Posting Exercise have an environmental science or green club¹⁰.

6.3 Proposed Locations

Football training under SP-CCAs can easily take place at the multiple ActiveSG stadiums islandwide. For instance, schools located in the central area can train at Bishan or Toa Payoh stadiums, whereas schools in the East can train at Our Tampines Hub or Bedok Stadium. For badminton, most stadiums in Singapore also have multi-purpose indoor sports halls for indoor badminton training.

For community service SP-CCAs, schools can partner with the zonal Community Development Councils (CDCs), with access to each constituency's community centre volunteering programs. Environmental-based SP-CCAs can partner with Nature Society Singapore, which segues into our next proposed solution, External Partnership-CCAs (EP-CCAs).

¹⁰ This is, yet again, based on a manual count of the number of CCAs offered by each secondary school as listed in the "Choosing Your Secondary Schools for Admission to Secondary 1 in 2022" booklet released by MOE. 33 schools out of 144 offer some form of green club, nature club or environmental science club.

FORMING EXTERNAL PARTNERSHIP-CCAs (EP-CCAs)

7. OVERVIEW

There is another way to introduce non-school based, centralised CCAs beyond SP-CCAs. MOE can partner with external organisations (hosts) to offer External Partnership-CCAs (EP-CCAs) to secondary school students. On top of typical school-based CCAs, students can opt to join these EP-CCAs on an annual basis as an avenue to enjoy themselves while gaining exposure.

We intend for EP-CCAs to take the concept of SP-CCAs one step further by offering the choice of centralised CCAs for novel (and by extension more diverse) CCA options. EP-CCAs are meant to further expand the choices available to students.

EP-CCAs will be offered within School Zones. Students will learn about EP-CCA options through Open Houses, and can bid for EP-CCAs on a zonal basis. This is similar to how schools conduct internal open houses and internal CCA trials and selections. EP-CCAs will count towards the LEAPS 2.0 framework, where teacher-in-charges from MOE will handle this administrative process. Much of the process is similar to how school-based CCAs or SP-CCAs are currently run. Lastly, we propose for funding to be covered under the financial resources allocated to MOE Zonal Branches that are managed by Cluster Superintendents.

8. PRECEDENT

We believe our proposal is feasible as there is ample precedent for it.

8.1 Children and Youth Sport (CYS) Framework

The CYS Framework aims to implement a structure for robust sporting programmes and capabilities in schools (SportSG, n.d.). It also serves as a platform for students to develop new skills. The CYS will expand students' exposure to sports, which aligns with our proposal of expanding students' choice of CCAs. Under the CYS is the Strategic Partnership CCA and the School Sports Partnership initiatives.

8.2 Strategic Partnership-CCA (SP-CCA)

8.3 School Sports Partnership Programme (SSP)

The SSP was introduced by SportSG to expose students to sports that are not offered as CCAs in schools (Aziz, 2019). While students typically engage in unstructured play during recess or after school, the SSP provides structure for students to conveniently pick up new sports, whether in school during recess or at a nearby sports centre (Fu, 2020). These sports are not considered CCAs, but they provide students options beyond the ambit of school-based CCAs.

8.4 Junior Sports Academy (JSA) Programme

The JSA programme exposes students with better physical abilities to various sports, aimed at helping them make more informed decisions on sport participation in secondary school (MOE, 2022e). Only nominated students can participate in the programme, where they play four different types of sports and learn about sports science (National Youth Sports Institute, n.d.). This provides students with a significant breadth of exposure to sports they may otherwise not have access to.

8.5 Combined School Teams

In rare cases, schools form combined teams with other schools. One example is the combined hockey team between Anglo-Chinese School (Barker Road) and Queensway Secondary School (Anglo-Chinese School (Barker Road), 2021). Another example is the combined basketball team between Blangah Rise Primary School and Alexandra Primary School (Blangah Rise Primary School, n.d.). As a result, more of their students could participate in CCAs which suited their interests.

8.6 Student-Initiated CCAs

According to MOE, students may also start their own activities with the school's approval, to pursue interests or ideas not found in current CCAs (MOE, 2022d). Some schools, such as Anglo-Chinese School (Junior), have special provisions for students who wish to train for a sport the school does not offer (Anglo-Chinese School (Junior), n.d.). Eunoia Junior College also offers a range of student-initiated CCAs, such as the School Ambassadors CCA and the Strategic Affairs CCA (Eunoia Junior College, n.d.).

8.7 External Organisations

External organisations already run a number of CCAs in various schools. The Singapore Cybersports and Online Gaming Association (SCOGA), for example, runs an Esports CCA (Singapore Cybersports and Online Gaming Association) at ITE College Central (Singapore Cybersports and Online Gaming Association, n.d.). The Singapore Youth Flying Club (SYFC) has also been running CCAs in secondary schools for 20 years, and currently operates in 17 secondary schools (SYFC, n.d.).

8.8 Evaluation of Precedent

Parts of our proposal already exist in current initiatives, as shown in this table:

Precedent	More Options/ Exposure?	Student Audience	CCA?	External Organisation?	Institution -alised?
SP-CCA	Yes	Secondary	Yes	No	Yes
SSP	Yes	Secondary	No	No	Yes
JSA	Yes	Primary	No	No	Yes
Combined School Teams	Yes	Secondary	Yes	No	No
Student- Initiated CCAs	Yes	Primary to Post-Seconda ry	Yes	No	No
External Organisations (e.g. SYFC)	Yes	Secondary to Post-Seconda ry	Yes	Yes	Yes
Proposed EP-CCAs	Yes	Secondary	Yes	Yes	Yes

The SYFC CCA and SP-CCAs are, in particular, very close precedents to EP-CCAs. SYFC is a CCA run by an external organisation, while SP-CCAs are centralised, non-school based CCAs. At its core, an EP-CCA seeks to merge these features, providing centralised, non-school based CCAs run by external organisations.

9. KEY DIFFERENCES

Notwithstanding the close precedents, our proposed EP-CCAs will be different from SP-CCAs and school-based CCAs in several ways.

9.1 EP-CCAs as Secondary, Opt-In CCAs

Firstly, EP-CCAs are only offered as secondary CCAs and should not substitute conventional school-based CCAs, especially in its early stages. This is because there is no guarantee EP-CCAs can meet the standard set by school-based CCAs. Only after the policy is studied and refined over time can EP-CCAs be rolled out as primary CCAs.

Additionally, this also accounts for concerns about attrition of membership in school-based CCAs and disbursement of funding - by making EP-CCA membership secondary and

optional, it would not affect membership of school-based CCAs, therefore reducing uncertainty for schools in allocating funds.

This dual CCA arrangement is an additional commitment for students. To keep it manageable for interested students, EP-CCAs should be held at a lower frequency, such as fortnightly. A lower frequency of CCA sessions is also more manageable for hosts to organise. If deemed beneficial, EP-CCAs can meet at a higher frequency off-season or during holidays, where students have less academic commitments.

9.2 Focus on Interest and Enjoyment

This is a difference between EP-CCAs and SP-CCAs, and between EP-CCAs and school-based CCAs. As earlier mentioned, SP-CCAs for sports or VPAs augment school-based CCAs by increasing the base of participation, which surfaces more talent. In our view, SP-CCAs should primarily serve to discover and nurture talent. This does not mean students cannot also enjoy themselves at SP-CCA, but that there is pressure for students to train and compete.

EP-CCAs, on the other hand, are for students to enjoy in a relaxed, informal setting. Following the previous point, having EP-CCAs as a second CCA, an additional commitment, may add to students' stress. This is why EP-CCAs should be structured not as an obligation for students, but as an avenue to relax, destress and enjoy themselves.

9.3 One-Year Academic Cycle for EP-CCAs

EP-CCAs will run for only one academic year at a time. There are two reasons for this.

Firstly, it provides students the flexibility to try different EP-CCAs out throughout secondary school. Students deeply interested in a particular EP-CCA may simply re-apply for it in the following years. On the other hand, if they find they do not like the EP-CCA, they can try something else the following year¹¹. Since EP-CCAs only run for one year, Secondary Two and Three students can apply for EP-CCAs too. Students who compete in the biennial SYF under their primary CCA can, for example, join EP-CCAs during the in-between lull years.

Secondly, this is because some organisations we engaged with (SBP, Coastal Natives) said they lacked the capacity to offer a holistic, four-year CCA programme. SBP is completely volunteer-run, while Coastal Natives only have one full-time staff. While they could potentially accommodate one cohort of about 10 students per year, they could not accommodate four cohorts across each year of secondary school. With a smaller-scale, one-year programme, EP-CCA hosts are better able to provide students a holistic experience.

¹¹ From our FGDs with students in IHLs, we discovered that clubs and Interest Groups (IGs) in Polytechnics and Universities function similarly in terms of commitment. Students can join for single-year periods, and move on to different clubs and IGs in other years. Across a spectrum of commitment levels, CCAs are high, clubs moderate and IGs low. This allows students to calibrate their CCA choices based on their desired commitment, which is something EP-CCAs seek to achieve as well.

9.4 Limitation of EP-CCA Choices by School Zones

Each EP-CCA choice will only be offered within one of the four school zones. There are two reasons for this: geographical proximity and simpler administration.

Limiting EP-CCAs to a particular zone minimises travelling time for students, which was a concern raised by students in SP-CCAs. Reduced travelling time also makes it easier to coordinate a common start time for students across different schools and mitigates concerns about student safety and transport cost. Over time, as EP-CCAs develop and expand, they can be offered in multiple zones at once.

This also simplifies the administrative process for managing EP-CCAs, as all oversight and funding occur within a single MOE Zonal Branch, under the supervision of that zones' Cluster Superintendents, rather than across zones. More broadly, it keeps implementation costs small. With that in mind, EP-CCAs would be simplest to administer in the East Zone, which has just 35 secondary schools, compared to other zones which have either 38 or 39 (MOE, 2022a).

9.5 Overview of Key Differences

Our eventual goal is for EP-CCAs to be fully-fledged, four-year CCAs, counterparts to school-based CCAs and SP-CCAs. However, this was infeasible due to several policy considerations.

Hence, the key differences are, in part, structured to make the initial implementation of EP-CCAs feasible, while giving it pathways to develop into fully-fledged CCAs in the future.

Differences	CCAs	EP-CCAs	Benefits of EP-CCAs over CCAs
Membership	Compulsory	Optional	Gives students flexibility to commit, based on their other commitments
Focus	Enjoyment and Talent Development	Enjoyment	Casual, low-stakes environment for students to relax and destress
Runtime	4 years	1 year	Accommodates EP-CCA hosts' capacities, student flexibility
Choices	Limited by school	Limited by school zones	More options for students, minimal disruption due to transport time

10. SELECTION AND NUMBER OF HOSTS

Since EP-CCAs are meant to offer novel and diverse CCA options to students, hosts should occupy a niche not yet covered by school-based CCAs in the zone. While this leaves a large pool of potential hosts, only EP-CCAs that can deliver a holistic experience - where students get to learn new skills, develop their character and interact with peers - should be selected.

10.1 EP-CCA Organisation Selection Matrix

Therefore, we propose that potential hosts be judged via five metrics outlined below. Since EP-CCAs are offered zone-wide, cluster superintendents could be responsible for judging and selecting hosts. These metrics are non-exhaustive.

10.1.a: Reputation and History

Has this organisation been around for long? Is the host a national association for that activity, or affiliated/recognised by one? The history and/or reputation of an organisation may inform us on the relevance and significance of their activities despite not being large enough to be mainstream.

10.1.b: Manpower

Do they have a leadership structure? Is it run by full-time staff, volunteers, or a hybrid? Do they have qualified instructors that can lead the EP-CCA sessions?

10.1.c: Experience in Related/Relevant Programmes

Does the host conduct regular outreach, tours or research? Were these targeted to the secondary school/youth population? How many people do their programmes reach? They may not have students in their ranks but perhaps their activities can readily be adapted.

10.1.d: Cost

Since zones are going to pay out of cluster financial resources, hosts should also demonstrate how they can be cost-effective in their operations.

10.1.e: Alignment to MOE's Strategic Interests

EP-CCAs should align with MOE's strategic interests, such as the development of 21st-Century Competencies. If an EP-CCA cultivates interdisciplinary learning e.g. environmental engineering, that can be counted as a point in favour of the EP-CCA.

10.2 Possible EP-CCA Organisations

To that end, based on our engagements with several external organisations, we ascertain that the following organisations may have the potential to be hosts for EP-CCAs because they meet most, if not, all, of the factors that we have outlined above.

- Singapore Cybersports and Online Gaming Association
- Coastal Natives SG

- Singapore Birds Project
- Singapore Sports Climbing and Mountaineering Federation
- Nature Society Singapore

Lastly, we propose that MOE start with five EP-CCAs. Limiting the number of EP-CCAs ensures that only hosts of suitable quality will be selected. This both ensures students get a holistic experience and sets a benchmark for future hosts to follow.

11. INTEGRATION INTO CCA SELECTION AND PARTICIPATION

The same processes governing the selection of CCAs in schools (open houses, registration of interest, shortlisting of students) will apply to EP-CCAs.

11.1 Open House and CCA Orientation

Students generally have two opportunities to find out more about CCAs. The first is during a school's open house. The second is during the school's internal CCA orientation, which is typically part of the Secondary 1 orientation.

11.1.a: Physical and E-Open House

All EP-CCAs in the same zone will host a physical open house at a central, agreed-upon location such as a school within the zone. If an EP-CCA's sessions will be located at a school, EP-CCAs can also choose to hold their open house concurrent with the school's internal open house. EP-CCAs may also opt for an online open house instead.

11.1.b: CCA Orientation

During schools' internal CCA orientations, schools offering EP-CCAs will inform students that the option exists. However, EP-CCAs will not be expected to operate a physical booth at each school. Students may instead refer to an online fact sheet or webpage, which EP-CCAs are required to provide – similar to the SP-CCA factsheets available at MOE's website.

11.1.c: Information Provided

The EP-CCA open house should convey important points, such as the rationale for EP-CCAs; the key differences between CCAs and EP-CCAs; the participating hosts and the discretionary appeals system. In particular, students should be told when and how frequently the EP-CCA is conducted, to gauge the required commitment.

11.1.d: Exclusion of EP-CCAs

If there is a nature conservation EP-CCA, but schools already have their own nature club or environmental conservation club, they can opt not to offer that particular EP-CCA to its students. This is to ensure the EP-CCA does not inadvertently reduce membership of the school-based CCA.

11.1.e: Student Representatives

For the first few years of open houses, EP-CCA booths have to be manned by representatives from the host and the ECCA TIC. As student membership in EP-CCAs rise, students may gradually take over the manning of open house booths.

11.2 CCA Selection and Bidding Process

11.2.a: Selection Criteria

EP-CCAs should mirror SP-CCAs in welcoming students of all abilities and levels of experience, as long as they have interest in the CCA. However, they may opt to have short selection trials if deemed necessary. Hosts are expected to organise their own trials and are expected to disclose their selection process to students.

11.2.b: Online Bidding

Since school-based or SP-CCAs function as students' primary CCAs, while EP-CCAs function as students' secondary CCAs, bidding for each can take place separately but concurrently. Students can register interest for EP-CCAs on a centralised online platform. Students from schools that do not offer the EP-CCA will be unable to apply. Students can bid for up to three EP-CCAs, ranked by preference.

In the event of oversubscription, hosts can use balloting, or the ranking of results from selection trials, to decide which students get into the EP-CCA. Again, hosts are expected to disclose how they shortlist students.

11.2.c: Discretionary Appeals

In the event a student who applied does not get into an EP-CCA they desire, they can appeal directly to the hosts.

11.3 CCA Sessions

11.3.a: Location

EP-CCAs can either conduct EP-CCA sessions in a venue they own or rent, or they can indicate that they would like to make use of a school's facilities. If they are using a school's facilities, MOE will arrange for a willing school within the zone to provide a physical location for the EP-CCA. If they are using their own venue, it still has to be within the zone, to manage travelling times for students.

11.3.b: Start Times

EP-CCAs involve students from different schools, who end school at different times. There is thus a need to coordinate a common start time for EP-CCAs, which would vary based on the schools its students come from as well as its location. There is no

recommended start time. The host and EP-CCA TIC will establish a common starting time that works for all the students involved.

12. ADMINISTRATIVE COMPLIANCE

There are some regulations that will impose a compliance burden onto EP-CCAs, just as they do on school-based CCAs and SP-CCAs. This includes the following:

- Teachers-in-Charge
- Attendance Taking
- LEAPS 2.0 Framework
- Membership Changes
- Registration of EP-CCA Coaches
- Risk Assessment Management Systems
- Funding Records and Expenditure Claims
- Discipline and Conduct of Coaches and Students

12.1 Teachers-in-Charge (TICs)

TICs, which help to run the CCA in accordance with MOE's regulations, are structured differently in the EP-CCA framework. TICs are either attached to the EP-CCA or to the school.

12.1.a: EP-CCA TICs

Each EP-CCA would have one TIC who functions like a school-based CCA TIC. These TICs are responsible for taking attendance, keeping CCA records, registering coaches, managing funds and producing RAMS – similar to the teacher-mentors in the SP-CCA pilot (MOE, n.d. a). EP-CCA TICs should be present for all EP-CCA sessions.

12.1.b: School TICs

These TICs are in charge of all the students in their schools who are in EP-CCAs, even if students are in different EP-CCAs. Every school should have one school TIC from within the school's staff.

There are several reasons why school TICs are necessary:

- In the event a student is absent from EP-CCA, school TICs can verify whether the student had valid reasons or played truant.
- School TICs know the school's start and end times, which will help the EP-CCA TIC coordinate a suitable CCA timing for students from all the schools.
- If a student gets into trouble for misconduct during EP-CCA, **their school TIC** retains the right to take formal disciplinary action, not the EP-CCA TIC.

- Under LEAPS 2.0, a student's school-based activities and EP-CCA activities will be recorded on the same document. It would be the EP-CCA TIC's job to record EP-CCA involvement, but the school TIC's job to merge those records with other school-based involvement.

12.1.c: Selection of TICs

Both types of TICs should have prior experience as a CCA TIC.

While School TICs come from the respective schools, EP-CCA TICs can be selected from any school in the zone. A teacher from Sengkang Secondary School, for example, can be the EP-CCA TIC for a nature conservation EP-CCA, even if:

- No students in Sengkang Secondary participate in the nature conservation EP-CCA
- Sengkang Secondary does not offer subjects, electives, CCAs or other enrichment (such as ALPs) related to nature conservation

In our view, the most important criterion for an EP-CCA TIC is interest in the EP-CCA. In our example, the TIC from Sengkang Secondary would be a nature-lover who values their work in exposing students to nature. Designating additional TICs for EP-CCAs imposes a manpower burden on schools, but selecting the right teachers can turn this into a win-win.

12.2 Attendance Taking

Attendance will be taken in EP-CCAs the same way it is currently used in school-based and SP-CCAs.

12.3 LEAPS 2.0 Framework

12.3.a: Guidance for Hosts

Activities done under EP-CCAs, like all school activities, count towards LEAPS 2.0. Since the framework is new to EP-CCAs, it is unclear how students might meet LEAPS 2.0 attainment levels through EP-CCAs. As such, guidance is needed. We expect EP-CCAs to provide opportunities in all aspects of LEAPS 2.0, but not necessarily at the highest level of attainment.

12.3.b: Adapting the Parents' Guide

MOE could adapt the Parents' Guide for LEAPS 2.0 (MOE, n.d. b) to create a guide for EP-CCA hosts. This will complement the EP-CCA TICs' efforts to guide the hosts in tailoring activities to cater to student development.

12.3.c: Challenges in Adoption

The Participation and Service components of LEAPS 2.0 can readily be adopted by EP-CCAs. However, EP-CCAs may struggle in adopting the Leadership and Achievement components.

12.3.d: Leadership

Hosts may not have leadership positions for student members. They may need to create leadership roles amongst their student members e.g. Treasurer, Captain, Secretary and define their responsibilities to provide leadership opportunities.

12.3.e: Achievement

For a hypothetical nature conservation EP-CCA, it is unclear what school-, national- or international-level events there are, or if there are nationally-recognised achievements e.g. the NYAA for that specific field. Hosts should consult their EP-CCA TICs to see if ongoing projects like research or outreach can count under achievement instead.

12.4 Membership Changes

We agree with MOE's view that students should stay in the same CCA throughout secondary school (MOE, n.d. a), to reap the full benefits of CCAs. As EP-CCAs are already scoped to a single-year duration, we expect students to remain in it the whole year. Students have the option of not joining it the next year.

12.5 Registration of EP-CCA Instructors

As per MOE regulations (MOE, 2022b), CCA coaches need to be registered with MOE. Unlike school-based CCAs, where coaches bid for a CCA and compete with other coaches, EP-CCA instructors will not need to compete with others, since they are tagged to the host. Instead, given that we propose limiting EP-CCAs to a single MOE Zonal Branch, the Cluster Superintendents of that zone have to approve the registration of EP-CCA instructors. EP-CCA instructors should be background-checked to ensure students' safety.

12.6 Risk Assessment Management Systems (RAMS)

RAMS will be used in EP-CCAs the same way it is currently used in school-based and SP-CCAs. EP-CCA TICs shall work together with the hosts to produce the RAMS for the activities.

12.7 Funding Records and Expenditure Claims

Records involving money in EP-CCAs will be handled according to the system currently in place for SP-CCAs.

12.8 Discipline and Conduct of Coaches and Students

Prevailing regulations on appropriate conduct for coaches and students will apply. In the event of student misconduct, formal disciplinary actions can only be taken by their school.

The EP-CCA TIC would need to refer the student to the school TIC for formal disciplinary action.

13. IMPLEMENTATION COST

This section shall spell out the costs that may be incurred by MOE in order to run this policy, derived from the funding to cover additional manpower costs as well as the need to reimburse hosts in running their EP-CCA sessions

13.1 Manpower

As have been alluded to in Sections 10.1 and 12.1, there will be three key groups of people who will be involved in the operationalisation of EP-CCA, which are the following.

- MOE Cluster Superintendents and additional MOE officers,
- Teachers-in-Charge, both attached to EP-CCAs and Schools, and
- EP-CCA Instructors.

13.1.a: MOE Cluster Superintendents and Additional Officers

Cluster Superintendents in the zone may be assisted by two to three additional MOE officers attached to the zone to select suitable EP-CCA hosts that meet the matrix as expounded in Section 10.1. Additionally, the short duration of one academic year for EP-CCAs, that allow for hosts to quit the EP-CCA scheme at the end of the year, may necessitate the search for a new host on a rolling basis.

As we have recommended for the policy to start in the East Zone, which has seven clusters, this will mean there will be a total of seven Cluster Superintendents. The additional two to three officers assisting the selection would bring the total number for this to **nine or ten key officers in charge of selecting the hosts**.

13.1.b: Teachers-in-Charge

In our proposal, each school will need a school TIC, and each EP-CCA an EP-CCA TIC. In the East Zone, this means we will need 35 school TICs and five EP-CCA TICs, **totalling up to 40 TICs**.

13.1.c: EP-CCA Instructors

Hosts may rely on full-time/part-time staff or volunteers to act as instructors and run their sessions. Estimating the number of instructors that will be onboard this scheme is not possible due to the different EP-CCAs that hosts may want to offer.

13.2 Funding

As Section 13.1 has identified the three key groups in operationalising EP-CCA, the following section attempts to expound on the financial costs that MOE has to bear due to the manpower allocation and the overall scheme.

13.2.a: Costs for MOE Staff

We believe that the costs should not be too onerous to fund the manpower from MOE's side, specifically the Cluster Superintendents, additional officers, and TICs, considering they are all full-time MOE staff and are already on MOE's payroll.

However, increased remunerations should be provided to the Cluster Superintendents and their additional officers for the added portfolio of having to evaluate prospective hosts. Similarly, the five EP-CCA TICs should also be offered increased remunerations as they would have to spend additional time outside curriculum hours to supervise CCA sessions that may not be within their school's compounds. Additionally, EP-CCA TICs should also be allowed to claim transport costs to get from their schools to the EP-CCA training locations.

The respective schools' CCA HODs can take the role of the School TIC. Since the school TICs job scope is not as broad nor as onerous as that of EP-CCA TICs, we believe it is up to MOE's and/or schools' discretion on the remuneration that should be offered for the additional workload.

13.2.b: Costs for Host Organisations

Since the hosts are originally self-functioning and funded independently, MOE should subsidise the costs that the hosts incurred to function as an EP-CCA. This includes the salary of EP-CCA instructors, should they be full-time/part-time, or allowance if they are volunteers. Other applicable costs include location rent, transport, food and logistics required. In general, the following two questions can be used to determine if it is indeed claimable:

- (1) Is the particular item/cost required for the organisation to also function as an EP-CCA?
- (2) Is the cost/item being claimed reasonable; i.e. are there other alternatives or more cost-efficient options?

Currently, school-based CCAs are funded directly through the allocation provided by the school's CCA HOD, while funds disbursed to clusters are allocated by the Cluster Superintendent. Following the current arrangement already in place, it would be most logical for the EP-CCAs to receive their funding and claim their costs directly from the Cluster Superintendents.

13.2.c: Costs to the Students

Individual students should not be made to pay for any EP-CCA equipment, membership fees and any other matters that are required for the functioning of the EP-CCA. This is because the hosts can claim the costs from MOE through the Cluster Superintendents.

However, the students do have to fork out their own transportation costs, which we believe should not be too onerous on the average secondary school student who pays student fare on public transport.

Having said that, MOE should make arrangements for students on the Financial Assistance Scheme to claim for transport subsidy as well, so that EP-CCAs will remain accessible to all students in the zone regardless of socio-economic status.

14. TIMELINE AND EVALUATION

In our view, a three-year lead time between initial preparation and initial implementation is sufficient. This factors in the time taken to select hosts, for parents and students to consider EP-CCAs, and manpower reallocation in schools to accommodate EP-CCAs. The details of this timeline are as follows:

Year 1	MOE begins to seek feedback on EP-CCAs from key stakeholders such as staff and students. Concurrently, MOE begins reaching out to potential EP-CCA hosts to onboard them and acquire feedback. Based on input from the hosts, MOE then makes an estimate of the implementation cost. Feedback to be received and compiled by the mid-year. If MOE decides to proceed after considering the feedback, they can publicly announce the future implementation of EP-CCAs. (The policy will be implemented in Year 4, or when the current cohort of P4 students enter Secondary 1.) The selected zone's Cluster Superintendents would then begin shortlisting EP-CCA hosts based on Section 10.1. The ideal system would be that the EP-CCA hosts present proposals to Cluster Superintendents in order to showcase their eligibility for the programme, which has limited availability. However, it may be the case that the hosts have to be approached first, at the start, as the initiative is still untested. By the end of the year, the list of EP-CCA hosts, and the zone they will operate in, should be finalised and the policy should be adjusted according to the feedback gathered.
Year 2	Based on finalised plans for EP-CCAs, MOE will need to brief schools in the zone on which EP-CCAs are available. MOE will also explain the onboarding process and compliance requirements. This gives schools time to decide if they want to exclude any EP-CCA as an option, to allocate manpower for school TICs and to shortlist potential EP-CCA TICs. Simultaneously, hosts should decide on the number of students they can accommodate and the funding they would require from the zone. As hosts have the option of using a school's facilities instead of their own, they would need to

	declare that too. MOE can then coordinate with schools to see which school is willing to offer their facilities for EP-CCA usage. By year-end, MOE should finalise the EP-CCA TICs, locations and expected membership.
Year 3	The first cohort of students who will experience EP-CCAs are now P6. As such, publications regarding choosing secondary schools (such as the Secondary 1 Information Booklet) should contain information on EP-CCAs. Beyond this, MOE should set up a page on its website introducing EP-CCAs, similar to the page it has on SP-CCAs (MOE, 2022c). Hosts and EP-CCA TICs should familiarise themselves with compliance requirements, such as the LEAPS 2.0 framework. They will need to finalise their plans for next year, including the activities for students and frequency of CCA sessions. Schools will need to finalise manpower allocations. The earliest open houses start at the middle of the year. This is when EP-CCAs will formally begin their work, through setting up open house booths at schools.
Year 4	EP-CCAs officially open for the now-Secondary 1 cohort. Though our proposal stipulates that Secondary 2 and 3 students can join EP-CCAs, only Secondary 1 students are eligible in the first year of implementation (Year Four). Secondary 2 and 3 students will be able to apply in Years Five and Six respectively.
Following Years	Subsequently, MOE will conduct an annual review of the EP-CCA list, bringing on new hosts and phasing out incompliant or underperforming hosts where required.

The following is a separate, more granular timeline outlining how this policy will play out in each academic year, beginning from Year Four:

T1W2 - T1W4	During each school's CCA orientation, students are informed that they may opt for an EP-CCA on top of their school-based CCA.
T1W4 - T1W5	The EP-CCA registration period commences to precede/coincide with the in-school CCA selection period. Secondary Two students are open to apply from the second year of implementation, while Secondary Three students are open to apply from the third year onwards.
T1W7	Host and EP-CCA TICs will decide on a common starting time that suits all students, and the EP-CCA commences.
T3W10	Hosts need to indicate to MOE if they will continue running an EP-CCA next year or terminate it.

T4W1	EP-CCAs have to stand down for students to prepare for their year-end examinations. Hosts can decide if they want to end sessions then or resume operations after the examination season until the end of the calendar year.
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MOE should seek feedback and conduct a yearly review of the policy. On top of that, there should be a major review at the fourth year of implementation (i.e. Year Seven) when the first batch of students to undergo EP-CCAs turn Secondary 4. This is because this first batch of students will be in a better position to provide constructive feedback on the policy.

15. STAKEHOLDERS

Our proposal for EP-CCAs aims to advance the interests of all parties involved while addressing their concerns.

15.1 Schools and Teachers

Interests

Schools want students to join a CCA that meets their interest, and so want to provide as many meaningful options as possible.

Concerns

Schools need to manage the allocation of manpower and money. Every additional CCA creates additional responsibilities for teachers, who have to procure coaches, take attendance, mentor the students and chaperone CCA sessions, amongst other things. As teachers already take on many responsibilities on top of teaching, schools may have little spare capacity to accommodate an additional EP-CCA. The manpower requirements should thus be kept low.

As for money, schools are awarded budgets based on their student headcount¹². They have autonomy to allocate this across their CCA and non-CCA programmes. Money spent on EP-CCAs invariably means money not spent elsewhere.

Since the EP-CCA functions as a secondary CCA, schools may also be concerned that students are unable to juggle both their school-based CCA and their EP-CCA. In fact, some schools explicitly advise against joining two CCAs (Tampines Secondary School, n.d.). EP-CCAs thus need to be set at a lower commitment level than school-based CCAs.

¹² As explained by Mr Lee Lis King (MOE) during a MOE-MAJU engagement session.

15.2 MOE

Interests

As with schools and teachers, we believe MOE seeks to offer CCAs which help students develop holistically, while catering to their diverse range of interests.

Concerns

We believe MOE will be concerned with the quality of EP-CCAs. Since they are hosted by external organisations, there is no guarantee that EP-CCAs can match the quality of school-based or SP-CCAs currently provided by MOE. Thus, there are minimum standards which EP-CCAs have to meet.

As with teachers, MOE will need to take on additional responsibilities, primarily sourcing for EP-CCA hosts and approving them.

As EP-CCAs are not school-based, funding for EP-CCAs will come from cluster financial resources (MOE, 2021b), rather than individual schools. This effectively shifts the burden of cost from individual schools to the cluster. Thus, EP-CCA costs must be prudently managed.

15.3 External Organisations

We obtained feedback from five external organisations regarding our proposal: Singapore Esports Association; Singapore Cybersports and Online Gaming Association (SCOGA); Coastal Natives SG; Singapore Birds Project (SBP) and Singapore Sports Climbing and Mountaineering Federation (SMF).

Interests: Each organisation expressed a desire to expand outreach to youths, such as secondary school students. Some, such as SCOGA, already have programmes catered to secondary schools. SCOGA also runs an eSports CCA at ITE College Central. Some organisations view student participation as an avenue for talent development (SMF), while others wish to share their passion and inspire students (Coastal Natives). This is particularly important for groups that lack avenues to reach students (SMF and SBP).

Concerns: One major concern is restructuring and compliance. Organisations are volunteer-run and not structured as a CCA. The work involved in restructuring the programme to fit the restrictions of a CCA, such as coming up with a training plan and in operating the CCA may be too cumbersome. This workload needs to be kept low so that the benefits of having student membership from hosting an EP-CCA outweigh the costs of compliance.

Organisations are also concerned with the availability of a venue. Some organisations (SBP) do not have a central location for conducting training. They mentioned that schools would have to provide a venue if they ran training for EP-CCA members.

A final common concern was that activities would not give students ample opportunity to meet LEAPS 2.0 requirements. Coastal Natives, for example, does not have any measurable metric for achievement, while SMF does not have opportunities for leadership and service outside of their internship programme.

15.4 MCCY

Interests: As mentioned above, SP-CCAs (athletics and ethnic dance) have strategic value to MCCY. Through exposing students to sports or arts that MCCY considers has strategic value, EP-CCAs can value-add too. For example, a SCOGA EP-CCA could build on Singapore's recent success with esports at the 2021 SEA Games.

More broadly, EP-CCAs can contribute to societal and government aims, such as increased appreciation of the arts, greater awareness of climate change or volunteerism. Greater exposure to sports will also contribute towards SportSG's "Live Better Through Sport" vision.

Concerns: NIL

15.5 Students

Interests. According to FGDs amongst students in SP-CCAs, students were happy to have the option of an SP-CCA that could better meet their interest. Students are looking for CCAs from which they can learn, make friends, have fun, and even gain experience for future careers.

Some students feel that CCA choices are sufficient while others feel they are restrictive. On balance, offering more choices will satisfy more students.

Concerns. One key concern raised in FGDs was loss of shared identity within the school. As SP-CCAs enable inter-school mixing in the place of intra-school mixing, some students felt that they missed out on bonding opportunities with their schoolmates.

Another key concern is academic commitments. Many students will be deterred from taking up EP-CCAs as a secondary CCA since they are an additional commitment, unless they can be sufficiently convinced that EP-CCAs are worth their time.

Some students also attended schools or lived particularly far away from the SP-CCA locations. For them, travelling to and from their SP-CCA added two to two and a half hours of travelling time, almost equal to the actual duration of the SP-CCA training. This additional hurdle of travelling time should be minimised where possible.

Some students' parents also opted out of SP-CCAs, citing concerns of malingering. They were concerned, with their children regularly travelling outside of school for SP-CCA, that they would get into trouble outside rather than attending their CCA punctually.

16. EVALUATION AND LIMITATIONS

16.1 More Choices Do Not Mean Higher Take-Up

Students may not take up EP-CCAs just because they are offered as choices. Just because a choice exists does not mean students know about it. Just because students know about it does not mean they want it. And just because students want it does not mean they can have it.

There are potential barriers at each step of this chain. Students may be completely unaware that EP-CCAs exist. Even if they were, they may not realise the value of certain EP-CCAs, or possess the initiative to seek out EP-CCAs. For example, students would not appreciate doing beach cleanups with Coastal Natives, if they did not first understand the value of environmental conservation and the urgency of climate change.

At the age of 13, Secondary 1 students may be too young to appreciate different choices, or exercise intentionality in choosing CCAs. And even if they did, external factors, such as parental influence, can prevent students from taking up their desired EP-CCAs.

There is thus a knowledge gap that needs to be closed, whether it is raising awareness of EP-CCAs, teaching students how to pick a CCA wisely, or educating their parents on the benefits of EP-CCAs. These are interventions that need to occur in tandem with our proposal.

An extension of this is that a higher quantity of choices is only meaningful if those choices are also of suitable quality. EP-CCAs are meant to be relaxed and enjoyable. This will attract genuinely interested students, but it may also attract students looking to bumble their way through four years of CCAs. CCAs filled with the latter type of students add to the quantity of choices, but not in a meaningful way.

16.2 Alternative Pathways

This policy proposal is designed to help students make the most out of CCAs. The pathway through which it does so is in offering more choices. However, there are alternative pathways for maximising the utility of CCAs.

One such alternative is to target CCA absenteeism, and more broadly school absenteeism. While there are students who participate in CCAs they did not choose, there are also students who due to absenteeism may not be participating in CCAs at all. As such, our proposal only targets one aspect of the issue.

As issues are almost always multifaceted, they can only be addressed if met with a host of policy interventions, rather than singular policies. By addressing just one aspect of the issue, our proposal is a meaningful but incomplete solution.

16.3 Conflicting School Schedules and Policies

Some schools schedule all school-based CCAs on fixed time slots, on fixed days of the week. This can give rise to a situation where school A has CCAs on Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays, while school B has CCAs on Tuesdays and Thursdays. Such arrangements make it impossible for EP-CCAs to schedule a common time. These have to be worked out internally by participating schools.

Additionally, schools have varying policies with regards to joining two CCAs. Some schools prohibit it entirely; some schools let students do it under certain conditions; some schools encourage it for all students; and some schools mandate it entirely. As EP-CCAs are a second CCA, whether or not students can join also has to be worked out internally by participating schools.

16.4 Interest Creates Exposure, Exposure Creates Interest

While interest may drive a student to take up a particular EP-CCA, exposure to said EP-CCA can equally spark interest in a student. It is important to offer students more CCA choices so they can pursue existing interests, but it is also important to offer students more CCA choices so they can develop new ones.

17. FUTURE EXPANSIONS

17.1 Conversion to Primary CCA

It is likely that some students participating in EP-CCAs end up discovering new passions there. These students may want to remain in the EP-CCA for the rest of secondary school, even if the host decides not to host their EP-CCA again. We could explore allowing students to convert EP-CCAs into their primary CCA, on a case-by-case basis with the school's and the host's approval.

17.2 Expand Zone Limits

EP-CCA participating schools are currently confined to zones to minimise travelling time for students. This creates a situation where North Zone schools, for example, cannot take part in South Zone EP-CCAs, even though some North Zone schools are geographically very close to South Zone schools (for example, Catholic High [North Zone] and Raffles Institution [South Zone]). Instead of using zonal limits as a proxy for travelling times, eligibility for participation in EP-CCAs can be based on actual travelling time, which is a more flexible but more complex system.

17.3 More Flexible Appeals Channel

This policy provides a discretionary appeals channel for students from within the relevant zone who applied for an EP-CCA but did not get in. This appeals channel can be expanded to

allow students from outside the relevant zone to appeal into an EP-CCA, on a case-by-case basis. This effectively expands an EP-CCA's reach from zone-wide to nationwide.

18. CONCLUSION

Fundamentally, we believe that MOE should **expand the range of CCAs available** to students where reasonable. Along this thinking, we have formulated a reasonable plan for introducing EP-CCAs.

In addition, we have sought to **balance the demands and concerns of stakeholders**, to ensure that the policy works in the interest of all parties involved. The policy is structured such that most of it can be **integrated with existing systems**, while new elements are kept as simple as possible.

MOE has gone to great lengths to ensure students participate in and enjoy a wide range of CCAs. The SP-CCA pilot, a policy innovation, demonstrates this commitment. We believe that beyond expanding SP-CCAs, MOE can go one step further to introduce EP-CCAs, which will introduce novel and diverse CCA options to students. This, we believe, will **create a win-win situation** that benefits students, hosts, and even contributes to long-term strategic interests.

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